For Jonathan Brinbaum, Managing Director, Watches, Bvlgari, a watch is more than a measure of time. It is a memory, a birthday ritual and, most importantly, a connection with his father.

When he was eight, his father began gifting him a watch on his birthday. As a child, Brinbaum would eagerly await the occasion, sometimes thinking about what he might receive the following year even as he unwrapped the one in his hands. The brand mattered little. What stayed with him was the feeling of owning a timepiece, something that made him feel a little closer to his father.

That childhood emotion has found a professional expression. As the head of Bvlgari's watch business, Brinbaum now works in an industry where craftsmanship, heritage, and technical ingenuity meet the personal desire to own something beautiful.

On a pleasant morning in Mumbai, Brinbaum talks to *BT* about the Roman luxury maison's ambitions for its watchmaking business. Best known for its jewellery and Italian design, Bvlgari wants to build a deeper connection with Indian watch collectors, drawing on its distinctive blend of Roman-inspired aesthetics and Swiss watchmaking expertise. He believes India is a long-term growth engine for the category. With three directly operated stores and more than 10 partners in the country, the brand plans to keep expanding its retail network while adapting to India's varied consumer preferences. Edited excerpts:

Q: Bvlgari is best known for jewellery. What distinguishes its fine watchmaking business?
A: We were born as a Roman jeweller, inspired by the Eternal City, its architecture and its symbols. Watches have occupied our thoughts for more than 100 years, but our shift towards true Swiss savoir-faire in watchmaking has taken place over the past 25 years. We acquired the Daniel Roth and Gérald Genta businesses and moved from being a jeweller-watchmaker, primarily associated with symbols such as Serpenti, to a more deliberate Swiss watchmaker. That is our unique DNA today: a brand born as a jeweller that now carries Swiss expertise in watchmaking.

Q: How do you convince serious watch collectors to add a Bvlgari timepiece to their collection?
A: We approach the brand through two distinct strengths. The first is our resonance with women in watchmaking. Serpenti and our jewellery watches appeal through their symbolism, history and design. The emotion behind these pieces comes from their inspiration and heritage.

The second is our technical expertise, particularly through Octo Finissimo collection. For more than a decade, we have pushed the boundaries of thinness, making it our point of difference. The idea was to create an elegant men's watch that could slip comfortably under a shirt. At the time, there was no calibre thin enough to deliver that design, so Bvlgari decided to craft one.

Q: How do you balance technical ambition with recognisable design, particularly in women's watches?

"Our unique DNA today is that we are a brand born as a jeweller that now carries Swiss expertise in watchmaking"